# Historical Maps of the Medieval & Early Modern World

*An Instructional Cartographic Guide for ArcGIS Story Maps*

Six Historical Maps with Cartographer Profiles, Historical Context, and Points of Interest

# Map 1: The Attack on Vienna — 1529 (Meldeman Plan)

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## The Cartographer

Niklas Meldeman (also spelled Meldemann) was a German-Austrian printer, painter, and publisher who operated in Nuremberg and Vienna in the early sixteenth century. He is best remembered in cartographic history for commissioning and publishing the famous circular panoramic plan of Vienna in 1530, an extraordinary document that preserved a vivid eyewitness account of the first Ottoman siege of the city.

## Historical Facts About the Map

- Shortly after the 1529 siege ended, Meldeman traveled to Vienna and acquired a drawing from an anonymous artist who had reportedly climbed to the top of St. Stephen's Cathedral during the siege itself, sketching the chaos below in real time. Meldeman had the work engraved onto six woodblocks and published it in Nuremberg in 1530.
- The map is not topographically precise; instead it emphasizes military importance, showing fortifications in detail while minimizing civilian buildings. This reflects the military-intelligence purpose of siege maps in the sixteenth century.
- The Ottoman siege of 1529 — led by Suleiman the Magnificent with a force estimated between 80,000 and over 100,000 men — lasted only about 20 days (September 27 to October 15) and failed largely because Suleiman's heavy siege artillery had been abandoned in the mud en route. Vienna's survival became a turning point in the Ottoman advance into Europe.
- The original woodcut resides in the Wien Museum (Historical Museum of the City of Vienna), having been purchased at auction in Leipzig in 1927. It measures approximately 81 x 86 cm.
- The Meldeman Plan is considered one of the earliest panoramic siege maps in European cartographic history, blending artistic illustration with practical military documentation.

## Points of Interest — Scavenger Hunt Style

### POI #1 — St. Stephen's Cathedral at the Center

**Look for…** The large Gothic church dominating the very heart of the circular map, labeled as the Stephansdom. Its tall spire towers above all other structures.

This is not just a landmark — it was literally the cartographer's vantage point. The anonymous artist climbed to the top of the cathedral's south tower during the siege to sketch the panorama. Placing the cathedral at the center was both topographically honest and symbolically powerful, representing the spiritual heart of Vienna under threat.

### POI #2 — Turkish Encampments Ringing the City

**Look for…** Look for rows of small tent symbols arranged in arc formations surrounding the city walls on the outer edges of the circular map. They are densely packed and extend in all directions.

These represent the Ottoman besieging force estimated at over 80,000 soldiers. The encircling visual conveys the sense of total isolation Vienna felt — cut off from any relief. The Ottoman failure to breach the walls with light artillery ultimately forced their withdrawal.

**POI #3 — The Burning Suburbs**

**Look for…** Look for small flame symbols and darkened areas in the neighborhoods just outside the city walls, especially to the west and south.

As the Ottomans advanced, Vienna's defenders deliberately burned the suburbs to deny shelter and cover to the attacking forces. This tactic, though devastating for the inhabitants, contributed significantly to the city's survival by slowing the Ottoman approach.

**POI #4 — The City Walls and Bastions**

**Look for…** Trace the irregular, thick polygonal boundary that divides the ordered city center from the chaos outside. Look for small towers and projecting bastions at intervals along the wall.

Vienna's medieval walls, while aging, held firm against the lighter artillery Suleiman was forced to rely on after leaving his heavy guns behind. The siege revealed their vulnerability, however, triggering a comprehensive modernization project completed in 1548, with eleven new bastions.

**POI #5 — The Danube River and Islands**

**Look for…** Look for the winding waterway shown along the upper portions of the panorama, with small islands visible mid-channel.

The Danube was both a strategic asset and a logistical challenge. It provided Vienna with a natural defense on its north side and limited where the Ottomans could position forces. Control of the river crossings was vital to any siege operation in this region.

**POI #6 — Five Heraldic Shields**

**Look for…** Locate five coats of arms arranged in the decorative border area of the map — look for shield-shaped emblems with distinct heraldic designs.

These shields identify the key political powers involved in the defense of Vienna, including the Habsburg dynasty. They served as a reminder that this was not merely a local event but a clash of empires — the Holy Roman Empire versus the Ottoman Empire — with the fate of Central Europe hanging in the balance.

## Web Links

Digital Viewing (high-resolution scan):
https://www.amusingplanet.com/2022/03/meldeman-plan-first-siege-of-vienna.html

Print-Optimized Reference (rare maps dealer with full description):
https://www.raremaps.com/gallery/detail/58749/der-stadt-wien-belegerung-wied-die-auff-dem-hohen-sant-seffa-camesina-meldeman

# Map 2: The Ebstorf Map (Ebstorfer Weltkarte) — c. 1234

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## The Cartographer

The Ebstorf Map is most commonly attributed to Gervase of Ebstorf, believed to have served as prior of the Benedictine convent at Ebstorf in northern Germany between approximately 1222 and 1234. Some scholars have proposed that this Gervase may be the same person as Gervase of Tilbury, an English-born scholar, lawyer, and courtier working in the court of the Holy Roman Emperor, whose encyclopedic work Otia Imperialia shares striking similarities in worldview — though this identification remains contested among historians.

## Historical Facts About the Map

- Made between 1234 and 1240, the Ebstorf Map was the largest known medieval map of the world (mappa mundi), sewn together from 30 sheets of goatskin parchment to form a square measuring approximately 3.6 x 3.6 meters (about 12 by 12 feet). It was discovered in the Benedictine convent at Ebstorf in northern Germany in 1843.
- The map was tragically destroyed during Allied bombing raids on Hanover in World War II in 1943. However, it was well documented through 19th-century chromolithographic facsimiles and photographs, and three reproductions were made in 1951-1953. One reproduction is now displayed at the Ebstorf convent itself.
- Unlike a modern map intended for navigation, the Ebstorf Map functioned as a visual encyclopedia of medieval knowledge, containing approximately 2,345 entries, including 1,500 pieces of text, 845 illustrations of buildings, rivers, islands, people, and animals. It covered theology, geography, secular history, myths, and bestiaries.
- The map is oriented with East at the top — the direction of Paradise and the rising sun — a standard feature of medieval Christian maps. Asia dominates the upper half, Europe occupies the lower left, and Africa the lower right.
- Its most distinctive theological feature was depicting the world as the body of Christ: his head at the top (East/Paradise), his hands at the sides (North and South), and his feet dangling at the bottom (West, at the Strait of Gibraltar). Jerusalem was placed at the navel — the spiritual center of the Christian world.

## Points of Interest — Scavenger Hunt Style

### POI #1 — Christ's Head at the Top of the Map

**Look for…** Look at the very top (eastern edge) of the map for an illustration of the crowned head of Christ, depicted in a golden halo or crown, presiding over the map's uppermost region.

This placement reflects the medieval belief that East is the direction of Paradise and the Last Judgment. The entire world map is literally contained within Christ's divine body — a profound statement that geography and faith are inseparable. East was so tied to the sacred direction that our modern word "orientation" derives from the Latin oriens, meaning East.

### POI #2 — Jerusalem at the Center (Christ's Navel)

**Look for…** Find the city of Jerusalem in the geographic middle of the map, depicted with a golden eight-sided medieval wall or circular enclosure. It sits at the heart of the composition.

Jerusalem's central placement was theological, not geographic. As the site of Christ's death and resurrection — and the spiritual navel of the Christian world — it had to occupy the center. The map was likely created to help pilgrims and crusaders visualize routes to the Holy Land.

**POI #3 — Paradise with Adam and Eve in the Far East**

**Look for…** Look at the very top of the map, in the easternmost region, for small figures of Adam and Eve near a serpent, and symbols of the four great rivers of Paradise flowing outward.

Medieval geography placed the Garden of Eden at the eastern end of the earth, the source of the Nile, Tigris, Euphrates, and Ganges. This belief, drawn from the Book of Genesis, shaped the orientation of Christian world maps for centuries. Finding Paradise on the map was finding the origin of all human history.

**POI #4 — Noah's Ark on Mount Ararat**

**Look for…** Search in the region corresponding to eastern Anatolia (modern Turkey) for a small rectangular ark-shaped vessel perched atop a mountain, labeled as Ararat.

The inclusion of Noah's Ark was standard in medieval mappae mundi. The map was not just geographic but a sacred history of the world from Creation to the present. Every major biblical event had its place, making the map a kind of illustrated scripture.

**POI #5 — Exotic Creatures and Monstrous Races**

**Look for…** Along the outer edges of the map, particularly in Africa and the far East, look for illustrations of fantastical beings — one-eyed men, dog-headed people (cynocephali), giants, or unusual animals like elephants and unicorns.

Medieval cartographers drew on classical Greek and Roman texts that described monstrous races inhabiting the edges of the known world. Including them was not naivety — it was scholarship. The edges of the map marked the boundary between the known and the unknowable, between civilization and the divine unknown.

**POI #6 — Christ's Feet at Gibraltar**

**Look for…** At the very bottom (western edge) of the map, look for the two feet or legs of Christ flanking the narrow channel between Europe and Africa where the Mediterranean meets the Atlantic.

The Strait of Gibraltar represented the western limit of the known world in classical and medieval geography. The famous "Pillars of Hercules" marked the edge of the inhabited earth. By placing Christ's feet here, the mapmaker declared that even the farthest limit of the world is held within the embrace of the divine.

## Web Links

Digital Viewing (high-resolution zoomable image):
https://www.landschaftsmuseum.de/Seiten/Museen/Ebstorf1.htm

Print-Optimized Reference (facsimile with scholarly description):
https://raremaps.com/gallery/detail/65079

# Map 3: Portolan of the Mediterranean — c. 1320–1325 (Pietro Vesconte)

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## The Cartographer

Pietro Vesconte (active 1310–1330) was a Genoese-born cartographer who conducted most of his professional work in Venice, and is widely regarded as one of the most important pioneers in the history of nautical cartography. He appears to have been the first professional mapmaker to regularly sign and date his works — a practice almost unheard of before him — and his 1311 portolan chart of the eastern Mediterranean remains the oldest signed and dated nautical chart that has survived from the medieval period.

## Historical Facts About the Map

- The portolan charts produced by Vesconte around 1320–1325 were created to accompany the Liber Secretorum Fidelium Crucis ("Book of the Secrets of the Faithful of the Cross"), a crusade propaganda treatise written by the Venetian statesman Marino Sanudo. Vesconte's maps were intended to help convince European rulers — including Pope John XXII and the King of France — that a new crusade was both logistically feasible and strategically necessary.
- Vesconte produced a world map, a detailed nautical atlas of five sheets, a map of the Holy Land, and city plans of Acre and Jerusalem for this project. Three manuscript copies survive, held today in the Vatican Library, the Zentralbibliothek Zurich, and the British Library in London.
- Unlike the symbolic mappae mundi of his era, Vesconte's portolans were built on empirical sailor-derived data, featuring accurate coastlines, rhumb line networks, and linear scale bars. His Mediterranean and Black Sea coastlines were so precise that subsequent cartographers did not significantly improve upon them for over a century.
- Vesconte's use of portolan techniques in a world map was a revolutionary development — he was the first to introduce the precision of navigational charts into the broader tradition of world mapping, effectively bridging practical seamanship and scholarly geography.
- His 1318 atlas, held in Vienna's Austrian National Library (Cod. 594), is considered the earliest surviving European atlas of nautical charts — a bound, multi-sheet book designed to be carried on ships.

## Points of Interest — Scavenger Hunt Style

### POI #1 — Rhumb Lines Radiating Across the Sea

**Look for…** Look across the open water areas of the map for a dense web of straight lines — some in black, some in red — radiating outward from hidden central points, creating a starburst pattern across the Mediterranean.

These are rhumb lines (also called wind lines or loxodromes), used by medieval sailors to plot compass bearings. By placing a ruler from their current position to their destination and finding the angle relative to a rhumb line, navigators could hold a steady compass course. This network was the GPS of the medieval Mediterranean.

**POI #2 — The Compass Rose**

**Look for…** Search for a central decorative circle or starburst shape, usually embellished with color, from which the rhumb lines radiate. There may be more than one on the chart.

The compass rose not only helped sailors read the wind directions but served as the geometric foundation for the entire rhumb line network. Vesconte was among the earliest cartographers to formalize and refine this navigational tool, which became the defining visual signature of portolan charts.

**POI #3 — Accurate Shape of the Italian Boot**

**Look for…** Look at the central portion of the Mediterranean for the unmistakable elongated peninsula of Italy, with its distinctive southward-pointing "boot" shape, clearly recognizable compared to earlier maps.

The extraordinary accuracy of Vesconte's Italian coastline — and of the Mediterranean basin as a whole — was unprecedented in medieval cartography. Modern cartometric analysis has shown his charts achieve a median error of under 30 km across the entire sea, an achievement that would not be surpassed for at least a century.

**POI #4 — The Holy Land and Palestine**

**Look for…** On the eastern edge of the Mediterranean, find a detailed section of the Levant coastline, labeled with cities such as Acre, Jaffa, and Jerusalem, possibly accompanied by a separate inset map of the Holy Land.

This portion of Vesconte's map served an explicitly crusading purpose — it was military intelligence. Marino Sanudo needed to show European leaders exactly where Christian forces would need to land, which ports to secure, and which fortifications to target. Maps like this represent the intersection of cartography, diplomacy, and holy war.

**POI #5 — Britain and Ireland in the North**

**Look for…** In the upper-left area of the atlas, find an elongated landmass representing the British Isles. Note its shape compared to the Mediterranean coastlines — it is less accurate but still an improvement over earlier attempts.

Vesconte produced some of the earliest and most ambitious attempts to chart northern European coastlines from available sources. His depiction of Britain was a marked improvement over his predecessors, revealing that cartographic knowledge was slowly expanding beyond the Mediterranean world.

**POI #6 — The Black Sea**

**Look for…** Find the enclosed sea in the northeast portion of the map — a large body of water connected to the Mediterranean through a narrow strait, roughly pear-shaped.

The Black Sea was crucial to medieval European trade routes — Italian merchants from Genoa and Venice maintained colonies along its shores, trading in grain, furs, slaves, and spices from Central Asia and the East. Vesconte's accurate depiction of this sea reflected Venice's deep commercial interest in keeping those trade routes open.

## Web Links

Digital Viewing (Vatican Library, signed 1320-21 copy):
https://digi.vatlib.it/view/MSS_Pal.lat.1362A

Print-Optimized Reference (British Library description and images):
https://www.bl.uk/catalogues/illuminatedmanuscripts/record.asp?MSID=8308

# Map 4: Mediterranean and Black Sea Portolan — 1339 (Angelino Dulcert)

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## The Cartographer

Angelino Dulcert (also known as Angelino de Dalorto or Angelino Dulceto, active c. 1320–1339) was a cartographer of Genoese origin who relocated to Palma, Majorca, where he became the founding figure of the celebrated Majorcan school of cartography. He is responsible for two of the most significant portolan charts of the fourteenth century: the Dalorto chart of approximately 1325 and the Dulcert chart of 1339, the latter being the first known portolan produced in Palma and the direct ancestor of the brilliant Catalan Atlas tradition.

## Historical Facts About the Map

- The 1339 Dulcert chart is signed in Latin: "Angelino Dulcert me fecit in civitate Maioriche anno MCCCXXXIX" (Angelino Dulcert made me in the city of Majorca in the year 1339). It is held today by the Bibliothèque nationale de France in Paris (Rés. Ge B 696) and measures approximately 75 x 102 cm, composed of two sheets of parchment joined together.
- The chart covers the full Mediterranean and Black Sea basin, extending north to the British Isles and Scandinavia and south along the northwest African coast. Crucially, it includes one of the earliest cartographic depictions of the Canary Islands and the island of Madeira, documenting the expanding horizon of European geographical knowledge.
- The 1339 map is considered the founding document of the Majorcan cartographic school, which would go on to produce some of the most beautiful and influential maps of the late medieval period, culminating in Abraham Cresques's magnificent Catalan Atlas of 1375.
- Unlike earlier Genoese or Venetian portolans, Dulcert's charts introduced a more decorative and iconographic style, incorporating miniature illustrations of rulers, flags, cities, mountain ranges, and human figures, blending navigational utility with artistic expression.
- The chart features a notable depiction of Mansa Musa, the legendary ruler of the Mali Empire, and the Mongol ruler Özbeg Khan, reflecting the chart's remarkable engagement with the political geography of the wider medieval world beyond Europe.

## Points of Interest — Scavenger Hunt Style

### POI #1 — The Canary Islands

**Look for…** Along the far left (western) edge of the chart, beyond the coast of northwest Africa and the Iberian Peninsula, look for a small cluster of island shapes in the open Atlantic. One island may bear a red cross symbol.

The red cross on Lanzarote commemorates the Genoese explorer Lanzarotto Malocello, who reached the island around 1312-1339. This is among the earliest cartographic documentation of the Canary Islands, marking a pivotal moment in the expansion of European geographic awareness into the Atlantic — a prelude to the Age of Exploration that would come a century later.

**POI #2 — Mansa Musa, King of Mali**

**Look for…** In the interior of northwest Africa, find a small seated or standing figure of a dark-skinned ruler, richly dressed, often holding a gold orb or scepter. A label in Latin or Italian identifies him as the lord of Mali.

Mansa Musa's 1324 hajj pilgrimage — during which he reportedly distributed so much gold that he caused inflation across Egypt for over a decade — made him the most famous ruler in the Islamic world. Dulcert's inclusion of Musa reflects European awareness of West Africa as a center of extraordinary wealth, knowledge that would drive Portuguese exploration of the African coast throughout the 1400s.

**POI #3 — Özbeg Khan of the Golden Horde**

**Look for…** In the region north of the Black Sea and Caspian Sea — the vast steppe territories — look for a figure of a turbaned ruler or a labeled banner, with a Latin inscription identifying him as ruler of the Mongols or of Sarai.

Özbeg Khan ruled the Golden Horde (1313-1341), a powerful Mongol successor state that controlled the northern Black Sea trade routes critical to Italian merchants. Dulcert's acknowledgment of this ruler reflects the intensely practical nature of portolan maps — knowing who controlled the land behind the coastline was as important as knowing the coastline itself.

**POI #4 — The Rhumb Line Network**

**Look for…** Look across the open sea areas for the characteristic web of intersecting lines radiating from 16 compass points in 32 directions. The two wind roses — one near Barcelona, one near Antalya — are their geometric centers.

Unlike Vesconte's earlier charts, Dulcert's rhumb line network uses two overlapping wind roses covering the full length of the Mediterranean, a geometric innovation that improved navigational precision. This dual-rose system would become standard in all subsequent Majorcan portolans.

**POI #5 — The Atlas Mountain Range Styled as a Bird's Leg**

**Look for…** Along the northwest African coast (Morocco and Algeria), find a stylized chain of mountain symbols that scholars have noted resembles the leg of a bird when viewed closely.

This distinctive, almost abstract rendering of the Atlas Mountains reflects the blending of Arabic geographic knowledge with European cartographic conventions. Dulcert and his contemporaries drew on Islamic geographical sources — particularly Arab geographers — for information about the interior of Africa, a cross-cultural exchange that medieval cartography depended on.

**POI #6 — The Island of "Bracile" West of Ireland**

**Look for…** In the waters west of Ireland — in the open Atlantic — look for a phantom island labeled something like "Bracile," "Brazil," or a variant spelling, shown as a circular island.

This mysterious island, appearing in European charts from the 1325 Dalorto map onward, is the legendary island of Hy-Brasil from Irish mythology. Its appearance on Dulcert's chart reflects the oral traditions and sailors' rumors that cartographers incorporated alongside empirical data. Intriguingly, it may have contributed to the naming of the country Brazil when Portuguese explorers reached South America in 1500.

## Web Links

Digital Viewing (Bibliothèque nationale de France, Gallica):
https://gallica.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/btv1b52503220z

Print-Optimized Reference (Wikipedia with full-resolution image):
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Angelino_Dulcert

# Map 5: Map of the World from the Polychronicon — c. 1350 (Ranulf Higden)

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## The Cartographer

Ranulf Higden (c. 1280–1363) was an English Benedictine monk who spent most of his life at the Abbey of St. Werburgh in Chester, England, after taking his monastic vows in 1299. He is celebrated as the author of the Polychronicon, described by the medieval historian V.H. Galbraith as "the most exhaustive universal history produced in medieval times and the best seller of its age" — a seven-book Latin compilation of world history from Creation to his own day, drawing on about 40 different sources and surviving in over 100 manuscript copies.

## Historical Facts About the Map

- The oval world map found in copies of the Polychronicon (typically placed at the beginning of Book 1) is sometimes called the Higden Map or the Higden Mappa Mundi. It represents a simplified but widespread tradition of medieval world mapping, and because the Polychronicon was one of the most copied books in late medieval England, it is responsible for an extraordinary proportion of surviving medieval world maps — roughly one quarter of all known mappae mundi come from Polychronicon manuscripts.
- The map follows the traditional T-O schema: Asia occupies the top half, Europe the lower left, Africa the lower right, with the T-shaped body of water (the Mediterranean, the Nile, and the Don River) dividing the three continents. Jerusalem sits at the center.
- Unlike the grand Ebstorf or Hereford maps, the Higden map was a miniature illustration embedded in a manuscript rather than a stand-alone wall display. This made it widely reproducible and accessible to the literate clergy and nobility of England.
- The map includes 39 named towns, of which 14 are in England — a notably England-centric perspective that reflects Higden's monastic identity and audience. No other region receives such disproportionate coverage, revealing how geographic knowledge was filtered through national and cultural bias.
- The Polychronicon was translated into English by John Trevisa in 1387 and later printed by William Caxton in 1482 — one of the first books printed in England. The map thus survived not just in manuscript but in print, spreading medieval geographic ideas into the early modern era.

## Points of Interest — Scavenger Hunt Style

### POI #1 — The Oval or Elongated Shape of the World

**Look for…** Notice the overall shape of the map — an elongated oval or almond shape (mandorla) rather than a circular T-O form. Asia fills the upper half generously, while Europe and Africa share the smaller lower half.

The oval form of the Higden map is distinctive among medieval world maps. It reflects a compromise between the circular T-O tradition and a more elongated view of the world influenced by classical geography. The disproportionate size of Asia reflected the medieval belief that Asia contained the majority of the world's land and civilization.

**POI #2 — Jerusalem at the Center**

**Look for…** Find the label or symbol for Jerusalem positioned in the middle of the map, at the junction of the three continents and the T-shaped seas.

As in all Christian mappae mundi, Jerusalem's central position is theological, not geographical. It marked the site of the Crucifixion and Resurrection and was the spiritual destination of every crusader and pilgrim. Its centrality on the map told readers: this is the most important place on earth.

**POI #3 — England and Britain in the Lower Left**

**Look for…** In the lower-left corner (the European quadrant), find the British Isles — look for an oblong island labeled "Anglia" or "Britannia" situated off the northwestern edge of Europe.

The unusual detail given to England on this map — 14 of the 39 named towns — reveals the map's authorship and intended audience. Higden was an English monk writing for English readers. His local geography was precise; his knowledge of distant lands was largely borrowed from earlier texts.

**POI #4 — Paradise (Eden) in the Far East**

**Look for…** At the very top of the map (the eastern edge), look for a label or small scene depicting Paradise — possibly with a garden motif, river sources, or the names of Adam and Eve.

Medieval geography universally placed the Garden of Eden in the East, at the furthest known boundary of Asia. The four rivers of Paradise — the Nile, Tigris, Euphrates, and Ganges — were believed to flow from this single eastern source, a geographic idea that shaped European understanding of Asian river systems for centuries.

**POI #5 — The T-Shaped Water Dividing the Continents**

**Look for…** Look for the distinctive T-shaped body of water at the heart of the map: the Mediterranean running horizontally across the lower half, with the Don River (or Nile) and another waterway forming the upright of the T dividing the three known continents.

The T-O map design derives from the Roman geographer Isidore of Seville's Etymologiae (c. 600 CE), which described the three continents as divided by water in the shape of a T inscribed in an O. This ancient conceptual framework persisted for nearly a thousand years, shaping how educated Europeans imagined the structure of the world.

**POI #6 — Noah's Ark and Biblical Geography**

**Look for…** Somewhere in the upper (Asian) portion of the map, search for a reference to Mount Ararat or Noah's Ark — possibly a small vessel, a mountain label, or both.

Like all medieval world maps, the Higden map was also a biblical timeline. Major events from the Old Testament — the Flood, the Tower of Babel, the Exodus — were assigned geographic locations. The map was as much a sacred history as a geographic document, reminding readers that the shape of the world was determined by divine action.

## Web Links

Digital Viewing (British Library manuscript, Royal MS 14 C IX):
https://www.bl.uk/manuscripts/FullDisplay.aspx?ref=Royal_MS_14_C_IX

Print-Optimized Reference (Oxford, Bodleian Library image):
https://digital.bodleian.ox.ac.uk/objects/a7fe1f21-a97f-4d47-a6cd-b00c3be86c9a/

# Map 6: The Catalan Atlas — 1375 (Abraham Cresques)

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## The Cartographer

Abraham Cresques (1325–1387) was a Jewish master cartographer, instrument-maker, and illuminator from Palma, Majorca, then part of the Crown of Aragon. Working alongside his son Jehuda Cresques, he is credited with creating the Catalan Atlas of 1375 — widely described as the greatest medieval map of the world and the zenith of medieval mapmaking. Cresques served as official mapmaker to the King of Aragon, and was one of the most prized craftsmen in the royal court, uniquely positioned as a Jewish scholar with fluency in Catalan, Hebrew, and Arabic, enabling him to synthesize knowledge from Christian, Jewish, and Islamic geographic traditions.

## Historical Facts About the Map

- The Catalan Atlas was commissioned by Prince John of Aragon (the future King John I) as a royal gift for his cousin, who would become King Charles VI of France. Cresques and his son were paid 150 Aragonese gold florins and 60 Mallorcan pounds for their work — a significant sum that reflects the atlas's status as a luxury diplomatic object.
- The atlas consists of six vellum leaves, richly painted with expensive pigments, gold, and silver. The first two leaves contain cosmographic, astronomical, and astrological texts; the remaining four comprise the map itself, stretching nearly 10 feet wide when fully unfolded. It is now held by the Bibliothèque nationale de France in Paris (Ms. Espagnol 30).
- The Catalan Atlas was the first known map to incorporate an ornate compass rose and was the first atlas to synthesize the navigational precision of portolan charts with the encyclopedic breadth of medieval mappae mundi, essentially inventing the concept of the illustrated world atlas.
- Cresques incorporated knowledge from Marco Polo's travels in Asia, the voyage accounts of Sir John Mandeville, and Arabic-Islamic geographic sources, giving the atlas an extraordinary depth of coverage from the Atlantic to the China Sea — including one of the most accurate depictions of Asia produced in medieval Europe.
- After the 1391 anti-Jewish riots in Spain, Jehuda Cresques was forcibly converted to Christianity and later moved to Portugal, where he may have influenced the Portuguese school of navigation under Prince Henry the Navigator — creating a direct line between the Catalan Atlas tradition and the Age of Exploration.

## Points of Interest — Scavenger Hunt Style

**POI #1 — Mansa Musa, Emperor of Mali**

**Look for…** In the interior of West Africa, find a richly illustrated seated figure wearing a crown and holding a golden orb in one hand, extending a gold nugget or coin toward a turbaned camel rider. He sits on a golden throne.

This is Mansa Musa, ruler of the Mali Empire (r. 1312–1337), whose 1324 pilgrimage to Mecca became legendary when he distributed so much gold in Cairo that he caused severe inflation throughout Egypt for over a decade. Cresques's depiction transformed Africa from a blank

margin into a wealthy, powerful realm. The label reads: "This lord is called Musse Melly [Mansa Musa], lord of the Negroes of Guinea."

**POI #2 — The Compass Rose**

**Look for…** Find a large, ornate starburst or circular design in one of the sea areas — the first decorative compass rose ever depicted on a map. It radiates lines in multiple directions across the ocean.

The Catalan Atlas contains the first known ornate compass rose in cartographic history, transforming a navigational tool into a work of art. This innovation merged the scientific precision of portolan charts with the decorative richness of illuminated manuscripts, establishing a visual tradition that persisted in maps for the next three centuries.

**POI #3 — Marco Polo's Asia**

**Look for…** In the eastern panels of the atlas, look for a detailed depiction of India, China (labeled Cathay), and the Silk Road cities, populated with small illustrations of rulers, elephants, and text captions drawn from Marco Polo's accounts.

Cresques drew heavily on Marco Polo's Travels (Il Milione) for his depiction of Asia, making the Catalan Atlas one of the first European maps to incorporate Polo's first-hand geographic accounts. The result was the most detailed and geographically ambitious depiction of Asia produced in medieval Europe up to that point.

**POI #4 — The Camel Caravans of the Sahara**

**Look for…** Across the Sahara desert region in north-central Africa, look for small illustrations of camel caravans — strings of camels carrying goods, guided by turbaned figures — crossing the sandy terrain.

These caravans represent the trans-Saharan gold and salt trade that made West African empires like Mali fabulously wealthy. The caravans connected the gold mines of West Africa with the Mediterranean world, and Europeans were acutely aware that controlling or accessing these routes could determine economic supremacy. The atlas literally maps the flow of global wealth.

**POI #5 — The "Three Kings" and the Eastern Magi**

**Look for…** In Asia — possibly in the region corresponding to Persia or Central Asia — look for a group of crowned or robed figures, possibly on horseback, identified in captions as the biblical Magi (the Three Kings or Wise Men).

The inclusion of the Magi's homeland reflected the medieval European fascination with Eastern Christianity and the legendary Prester John — a mythical Christian king supposedly ruling in the East. These figures served as proof that Christianity extended far beyond Europe, encouraging crusading ideology and exploration.

**POI #6 — The Coastal Cities of Spain and the Iberian Peninsula**

**Look for…** On the western panels (leftmost leaves), trace the coastline of the Iberian Peninsula — Spain and Portugal — looking for densely labeled coastal cities shown as small tower symbols or colored rectangles, with flags identifying Christian and Muslim territories.

The level of detail on the Iberian and Mediterranean coastlines reflects the portolan tradition at its finest — these were working navigational charts for Mediterranean sailors and merchants. The Crown of Aragon controlled major ports along this coast, and the atlas served as a declaration of Aragonese commercial power as much as a geographic document.

**POI #7 — The Astronomical and Cosmological Panels**

**Look for…** On the first two leaves (far left) of the atlas, look for circular diagrams filled with text and illustrations, surrounded by figures representing the zodiac, the moon phases, or planetary spheres.

These opening panels represent a complete cosmographic system — the medieval understanding of time, the heavens, and the structure of the universe. By beginning with the cosmos and ending with the known world, Cresques framed geography within the larger divine order, connecting navigation to astronomy and faith in a unified medieval worldview.

## Web Links

Digital Viewing (Bibliothèque nationale de France, Gallica — full high-resolution): https://gallica.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/btv1b55002481n

Print-Optimized Reference (Smarthistory scholarly essay with panel images): https://smarthistory.org/catalan-atlas/

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## Notes on Using These Maps in ArcGIS Story Maps

Each Point of Interest entry in this guide has been formatted to function directly as a callout panel in ArcGIS Story Map. Simply copy the POI title as your panel header, use the "Look for..." sentence as your visual prompt, and follow it with the historical significance paragraph as your body text. Link each panel to the digital viewing URLs provided for interactive reference, and use the print-optimized links when preparing high-resolution printed materials or large-format displays.

For the best visual experience in a Story Map, consider pairing each POI with a zoomed or cropped version of the relevant map area. Most of the linked digital repositories allow region-specific zooming and screenshot export for exactly this purpose.